

Friends of Penelope

Volume One



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Printed on behalf of Friends of Penelope by Ó Donnaile Press
odonnailepress.com

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FOREWORD

MOLLY POTTER

Welcome to this poetry anthology—a diverse assortment of poems for you to explore. For me poems are akin to voyages through the thoughts, emotions, connections and experiences that shape our existence, expressed in a way where words can wield a succinct and commanding punch! I relish engaging with a poem as it weaves through my awareness, each line possibly delivering a revelation to digest, react to and relate with.

Poetry has the magic to cut straight to the core; baring our souls and displaying our vulnerability. This anthology includes poems that do just that. Gathered via a competition, these poets have dug deep and produced poems that are profoundly personal. As you read through them, you'll peek into someone's voyage and maybe see a little of yourself along the way.

SOFT

DALE RUNE CODY

I've been told
I've got a soft nose.

It's slightly weird to suppose -

I've got a soft everything else,
that I can see
and feel:
legs, chest, brain,
unsegmented torsoes.

I'd even buy
those who haven't heard me trumpeting down stairs
saying I've got soft toes!

But my nose?

I'm really not sure
how that arose.

Legs, chest, brain.
The only part of me
that's not soft
is my heart.
Too wrapped up in its woes.

With the half-decade I've had,
I've had to harden it
under layers
of rock and grave-dirt and ill-fitting clothes,

only to get it chipped
by the most distinguished of doves -
and the prettiest of crows.

Through a soft nose.

After all,

the one who told me that -
you -
had just kissed me.
(Or rather, I you.
If that's okay to disclose.)

So I, in my mildly-bewildered throes,

should probably stop nitpicking
and just be happy
that I'm one of the ones you chose.

ONE NEAT TRICK FOR IGNORING MURDERED CHILDREN

IZZY JARVIS

The Westminster mind
is a bigot in a cinema
smiling at the screen
suspending belief
the news theme rattles the speakers
and the special fx explode
again and again and again and again
the sets shattered to fragments
the actors
shining pieces
torn in the dust
blood for the dogs to lick
housebrick grit between their teeth—
suspend belief.
swallow a handful of popcorn
salty
and sweet.

the picture of the day
is a red rubble horrorflick haunted house
it's a cruelly tumbled cairn
where the buried choke
slow
and out of shot

and the hospitals starve—
empty wires and
incisions made by snipers
trace the lines of a tragedy
cold incubators
go quiet
a crying doctor begs to camera
no applause.
no Oscar.

the Westminster mind
is a coward fuck
sees the world as a theatre
to stomach the credits
dead names
reel past,
reality too has its producer directors
blockbuster bosses
trigger-pullers:
bigwigs in Whitehall
shake damp hands
with big shots
in Givat Ram.

Suspend your belief!
come and see!
the gorefest must-see revenge drama
the saga of the century
is screening now
the star of the show
is singing:

a handful of popcorn
helps a genocide
go down
helps a genocide
go down
helps a genocide

A LIFE OF DREAMS - PART ONE

ANDREW K COPEMAN (HE/THEY)

I have this dream of the person I am
Bold and brave and brazenly true,
I know the Hu(man) that sits in view
And the path that lies before me.

*I love that you're this,
I really would miss
If anything about you changed,
But I have to insist,
To make life easiest,
That you put it all out of range.*

I have this dream of the person I am
I'm kind and I care, I'm sweet and I swear
That I never, ever would dare
To hurt you, not even a hair.

*You're so good to me
Like no one would be,
I love the way you put me first.
I'm your priority
Let's keep that going, shall we?
Cause I promise I was cursed.*

I have this dream of the person I am
Strong with success, independent and capable.
I've learned to live as much as I'm able,
And build for myself something that's stable

*You know that I love you
But that just isn't true.
It's ok that you're wrong
cause I'll help you too,
Just follow my cue,
We'll be happy before too long.*

I had this dream of the person I was,
Opinions so rife, layers of life.

Hard as it was I pushed against strife,
And held dear to my heart my morals and values.

*So few are like you
But this is different.
I need you to do what I ask.
You owe it to me,
So be on my team,
It's such a small task.*

I have a dream I thought was real
A world I could really feel.
But now I've gone and gotten it wrong
messed up the words to a finely tuned song.
I don't know the ending and can't see the light
But hold onto the hope that I might.

A LIFE OF DREAMS - PART TWO

ANDREW K COPEMAN (HE/THEY)

I had this dream of the person I was
Scared and confused, lost and alone.
With no armour at all, entirely prone.
Really I was nothing at all.

*That's ok, we all have that phase,
The pain goes by faster these days.
You're doing so well so don't be so stupid.
You need some help, cause you're lost in a daze,
You could even call it a craze
We'll speak when you're lucid.*

I don't know who I am
I'm so glad for your guidance
Cause I just want to hide
I think I've lost all contro—

*I wound you up and so very sadly
Just like a human you exploded so madly,
How could you do that I never shouted.
I'll tell the world you've treated me badly
It never was me and I'll say that gladly,
Apart from those times I screamed and I pouted.*

I don't know who I am,
I don't know where I'm going,
I really can't stop the tears from flowing.
Is there a path before me?

*I'm glad to have gotten here, my dear,
It was really worth the ride
But it's here we part I fear,
Cause I'm ready to fly and you're just by-the-by.*

Oh.

*Hang on the hook though
Cause you never do know,*

*Maybe I'll need you again
When I'm stumped with nowhere to go,
I can run back here with baggage in tow
And call you my friend.*

Is that all I am, is that all I live
The expectation of service to give?
Now I'm alone with nothing of my own
And no one to be.

...

You left me here, stranded in fear
The echoes of life with you, my dear.
Where can I go what can I do
But live again better, without *you*.

BOTTOMS UP

DALE RUNE CODY

'Read from the bottom up' poems
Often precludes another appearance from
Negativity on my social media feeds
It's unsettling to think that
There are those who don't like it
But you can't deny
My adamance to the contrary
I'm sorry
It's tricky to imagine
Loving it the way most others do
That comes all too easy to me
But to hate that kind of thing -
I simply don't get it
It's highly likely that
They're being sincere in their flattery
In turn it's impossible to claim
The self-belief being espoused rings hollow
When you know you had to subvert it to get there
Some may say that
The transitions between those beliefs are just too obvious
You have to make weird sentence constructions to make your point
Case in point, see above and below:
The format just doesn't sit right with me
Sadly
It's my instinct to believe that
It's just a cheap way to get easy likes on Facebook
And yet I worry that
I'm being a snob
Or
I'm not in a good enough place to appreciate them
Or
I just don't like 'gotcha-positivity' things in general
One could make the argument
It's already an overplayed format
But I'm of the opinion that
'Read from the bottom up' poems resonate with people for a reason
I totally get that
Okay
(now read from the bottom up)

CHRISTMAS DAY BA

RUADHÁN Ó DONNAILE

A hundred men and boys,
panting, running,
in myriad jerseys, striped, crossed,
panting as one, so much that their steam was like a locomotive
or like a great vent,
that rose through the cobble chimneys
that rumbled and roared under their weight—
their faces red claret, bitten by sea winds, wispy and white,
or young but ruddy, eyes twinkling with love of the hunt,
arms wrapped around noon, afternoon, night,
until the great train had run out of coal and settled,
its wheels going on for a moment, then slowly rolling to a stop,
and finally coming back into position with a great sigh
doonies win

THE FORM OF POETRY

PERSEPHONE VON SYLVAN

If I were to write a poem to give a sense of me,
and my identity,
I'd want to fill it with wonder, wisdom, whimsy.
I'd want to give it for you to take,
just for pleasure's sake.
Imagine if you will,
all that I'd distil,
to create a picture of me
through my poetry.
I'd want you to see the best in me,
framed through my creativity.
I'd choose my words selectively,
so you would feel empathy.
I'd write so prettily
to affect the way you see me,
a lie told effectively.
But honestly, that wouldn't express me,
for who would I be
to subvert your view through poetry.
Would I change reality,
to rewrite myself favourably?
If I were to write with transparency,
the words would not flow so easily.
Would you perhaps prefer to see
my darkness in brutal accuracy?
My tainted soul bared openly,
shared in bittersweet reality.
In honesty, the truth of me
is perhaps too dark to be set free
in the form of poetry.
Because if you see,
I wrote about the real me,
I could only write it tenderly,
to create an image prettily.

FUN POEM #30

RUADHÁN Ó DONNAILE

The difference between you and I,
Is that you do not carry sorrow as I do.
When your heart has been ripped away and your life fell apart,
you were able, unencumbered, to claw your way back up a steep hill.
You do not carry sorrow as I do.
Misery flows downward, drowns the valley-dwellers,
gets into our bones and, like heavy metals, sits eternal.
You do not carry sorrow as I do.

LAST DAYS GO BY

ANDREW K COPEMAN (HE/THEY)

I found myself at the end of the world
And thought to myself:
“What a great pearl this, could have been.
Bright and beautiful, truly serene.
If only the smog hadn’t smothered us all,
In greed and deception,
The violence of war.
Now the night birds sing *all* times of day,
Come for life laid slain.
The pearl is pockmarked,
Cratered, and crusty,
No place for love to reign.
Quite near the end, I could contend,
Is the brain giving you something to spend;
A rush of euphoria,
Makes the pain go smoother.
But if happiness soared,
With the fighting all stalled,
Perhaps we could come to accord.
With peace all around and rescue found
Who would be left to profit from distress?
The grinding gears of suffering and gain
Uphold a structure of power to contain.
Empires rise, empires fall,
But the smog still comes to smother us *all*.”

MEMORY

how fickle memory is
my childhood

simply is not
there

The extraordinary capacity of the human mind to
systematically

fight War on

time

our decades

bleached of their intense contrast, and
subsequently not the
were

we even have

the

That's

people, songs, smells

stayed with us for a time

were only a

MEMORY

VANESSA ATALANTA

How fickle memory is.
My childhood simply is not there.
The extraordinary capacity of the human mind
to systematically fight war on time;
our decades bleached of their intense contrast,
and subsequently not there.
Were we even here?
Those people, songs, smells sat with us for a time,
then were only a...

Adapted from *The Body Keeps the Score: Brain, Mind, and Body in the Healing of Trauma*, Bessel van der Kolk (2014).

OBSERVATIONS THROUGH SEEING-HOLES

RUADHÁN Ó DONNAILE

Pent up in snaggle-toothed marchionesses horizontal mania,
mosses ripe,
aim - fire,
deer-blinked, sashed, flaunted, enthroned,
some trifle druzý cloudclocked on whimsy,
freeing the roosters.

SOUP

PERSEPHONE VON SYLVAN

I am soup.
Soup made of star dust and time.
The same soup as each soup before me,
the same soup as all of us,
as everything.
Not just the ooze we crawled out of,
clawing our way to existence,
but dust.
The dust that started it all,
the coalescence of everything
that ever was and is,
and is yet to be.
Dust and ooze.
And all the isn't,
everything that I'm not,
that is not,
was not
and won't ever,
is also in the soup,
or isn't.
But I am my own soup,
different to every soup before or after,
but still a product of it,
in the way all soups are.
All the potential,
for reality,
and the future
and everything,
is ingredients in the soup,
and my potential too.
I am just soup,
everything and nothing and soup,
like every other soup
in all of the history of soup.

UNTITLED

THEODORA MEDHURST

A frightened fool bear fruitless labour,
reciting fresh faced transgressions made bare.
The faults ache deep within,
stowed and stalling
on the promise of a recompense
that will only come to pass
on the dowry of painful deliberation.
Each waking frame of life
can't deny its past snapshots
as we can't doubt the misdemeanours of bygone pursuits,
to deny them is to deny the fruits it may bear,
you want to Bury them.
those moments.
And you must.
But to cultivate and bear your lot,
not to shroud your addled brass from view
keeping it veiled away.
In a phrase, Reap what you sow,
bear witness to your stagnant frenzy
and self abasement
don't bear it on your back
but lay a foundation
of which your stand upon now
with a horizon ever more clear from new heights.

Friends of Penelope is a Norfolk-based writing club with members from across the UK and beyond. We are a collective of queer writers who are inspired by the worlds both inside and around us to capture unique moments of our lives, which *Friends of Penelope Volume One* explores. The arts are often a reflection of real life and that leads many of us to the darker themes seen in some of the poems in this anthology, while others are more lighthearted.

We'd like to thank you for taking the time to read our first publication and supporting our contestants. We hope you enjoy our work.

Thank you to Molly Potter for judging our competition, and congratulations to Dale Rune Cody who won first place, and to Izzy Jarvis for second place! May there be many more winners to come.